New bounds for small two-colour Ramsey numbers

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23 October 2026

Abstract

We give upper bounds for the Ramsey numbers $\mathrm{R}(3,k)$ with $24 \le k \le 50$, for which Radziszowski's survey lists no upper bounds. They come from an exact bootstrap of lower bounds on the number of edges of triangle-free graphs with bounded independence number. It starts from the published values and lower bounds of Goedgebeur and Radziszowski. For instance, $\mathrm{R}(3,24) \le 201$, $\mathrm{R}(3,30) \le 297$ and $\mathrm{R}(3,50) \le 729$. If the table of Backelin's unrefereed report is also used, the bounds are 1 to 3 lower for $24 \le k \le 36$, except $k = 35$.

Deleting vertices from the quartic residue graphs of Lindsay and Cain gives $\mathrm{R}(4,21) \ge 260$ and $\mathrm{R}(4,24) \ge 370$. All certificates and witnesses are checked exactly by programs in the ancillary files.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. Primary 05C55; Secondary 05D10, 05C35, 05C69, 05C25, 68V05.

Keywords. Ramsey numbers; triangle-free graphs; edge numbers $e(3,k,n)$; quartic residue graphs; computer-assisted proofs.

1 Introduction

For integers $s, t \ge 1$, the Ramsey number $\mathrm{R}(s,t)$ is the least n such that every red-blue colouring of the edges of K_n contains a red K_s or a blue K_t; equivalently, every graph on n vertices contains a K_s or an independent set of size t. Multicolour numbers $\mathrm{R}(t_1,\dots,t_r)$ are defined in the same way. The current state of knowledge is collected in Radziszowski's dynamic survey [8], whose revision 18 we use for all comparisons, together with the later preprint [11].

This paper is a companion to a study of three-colour numbers [3], in which local Ramsey bounds inside colour neighbourhoods are combined with double counting and with flag-algebra certificates. The present paper gives new bounds for two-colour numbers: upper bounds for $\mathrm{R}(3,k)$ and lower bounds for $\mathrm{R}(4,k)$. The upper bounds are obtained by adapting the ladder procedure of [3, Section 5], and the lower bounds by deleting vertices from quartic residue graphs. Our results are listed in Table 1.

The upper bounds for $\mathrm{R}(3,k)$ (Section 2) and the lower bounds for $\mathrm{R}(4,k)$ (Section 3) are computer-assisted. Floating-point solvers and local search were used only to find certificates and witnesses, and in the negative experiments that we report. Every certificate and witness is checked in exact arithmetic by a program that does not share code with the search (Section 4).

number	previous	new	where
$R(3,k)$, $24 \le k \le 50$	no upper bound [8]	Table 2	Theorem 2.1
$R(4,21)$	≥ 242 [10]; ≥ 257 ([11] and [8, 2.3(e)])	≥ 260	Theorem 3.1
$R(4,24)$	≥ 343 (implicit in [7])	≥ 370	Theorem 3.1

Table 1: Our results. For $R(3,k)$ with $k \ge 24$, iterating $R(3,k) \le R(3,k-1)+k$, which is strict when both terms are even, or Shearer's bound [9], gives weaker explicit bounds (Table 2). Where the two rows of Table 2 differ, the smaller bound also uses the unrefereed report [2].

2 Upper bounds for $R(3,k)$

A $(3,k;n)$-graph is a triangle-free graph on n vertices with no independent set of size k. A $(3,k;n,e)$-graph is one with e edges, and $e(3,k,n)$ is the least such e. By analogy with [3, Section 3], where the term is used for three-colourings, $m_k(n)$ is a *valid lower bound* if every $(3,k;n)$-graph has at least $m_k(n)$ edges.

For a vertex v of a $(3,k;n,e)$-graph G, $N(v)$ is independent, so $d_v \le k-1$. Moreover, $G_v = G - N[v]$, where $N[v] = N(v) \cup \{v\}$, is a $(3,k-1;n-1-d_v)$-graph, as an independent set of G_v extends by v. As no edge lies inside $N(v)$, G_v has $e - Z_v$ edges, where

$$Z_v = \sum_{u \in N(v)} d_u.$$

As $\sum_v Z_v = \sum_v d_v^2$, valid lower bounds m_{k-1} give

$$\sum_v \left(d_v^2 + m_{k-1}(n-1-d_v) \right) \le ne.$$

This is the inequality of Graver and Yackel [5], on which Goedgebeur and Radziszowski [4] base their bounds for $k \ge 11$. It is the two-colour analogue of the density inequality [3, Lemma 3.3]. As $ne = \sum_v nd_v/2$, it says

$$\sum_v \varphi(d_v) \le 0 \qquad \text{where} \qquad \varphi(d) = d^2 + m_{k-1}(n-1-d) - nd/2.$$

The bootstrap. We bootstrap as in the ladder of [3, Section 5], with this inequality in place of the density inequality. Level $k \ge 11$ uses the bound B_{k-1} on $R(3,k-1)$ and the valid lower bounds m_{k-1} from level $k-1$. Level 11 starts from $B_{10} = 42$ [4, Theorem 6] and the values and lower bounds for $e(3,10,n)$ in [4].

Level k treats the orders $n = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$ in turn, records a valid lower bound $m_k(n)$, and stops at the first order it excludes, B_k, that is, the first n at which it shows that no $(3,k;n)$-graph exists. So $R(3,k) \le B_k$. In the same way, the procedure excludes a value e at order n when it shows that no $(3,k;n,e)$-graph exists, and a degree sequence when it shows that no $(3,k;n)$-graph has that degree sequence. We run the procedure twice, giving two *chains*: one from the inputs of [4] alone, and one that also uses the lower bounds of [2] described after the list below. At order n the procedure is as follows.

(i) The admissible degrees are the $d \le \min(k-1, n-1)$ with $n-1-d \le B_{k-1}-1$.

(ii) An order $n \geq 1$ is excluded if $\varphi(d) > 0$ at every admissible d (in particular if there is none), as $\sum_v \varphi(d_v)$ would then be a sum of n positive terms.

(iii) Otherwise let e_0 be the largest of the following bounds. The first is the bound of Radziszowski and Kreher [4, Theorem 2]. With $K = k - 1$, it gives the exact values

$$e(3,k,n) = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{for } n \leq K, \\ n - K & \text{for } K < n \leq 2K, \\ 3n - 5K & \text{for } 2K < n \leq 5K/2, \\ 5n - 10K & \text{for } 5K/2 < n \leq 3K, \\ 6n - 13K & \text{for } 3K < n \leq 13K/4 - 1, \end{cases}$$

and $e(3,k,n) \geq 6n - 13K$ for all n. The second exists when φ is positive at the least admissible d but not at every admissible d. Let $(d', \varphi(d'))$ and $(d'', \varphi(d''))$, with $d' < d''$, be consecutive vertices of the lower convex hull of the points $(d, \varphi(d))$, d admissible, with $\varphi(d') > 0 \geq \varphi(d'')$, and let $\alpha - \beta d$ be the line through them. The second bound is $\lceil n\alpha/(2\beta) \rceil$. This line has $\beta > 0$ and lies on or below φ at every admissible d, so

$$0 \geq \sum_v \varphi(d_v) \geq n\alpha - 2\beta e.$$

(iv) The extra step below, at the orders where the search applied it (each is recorded in the certificates), may exclude e_0 and some larger values of e. The recorded $m_k(n)$ is the least $e \geq e_0$ that it does not exclude. If it excludes every e from e_0 to $\lfloor n(k-1)/2 \rfloor$, the most edges possible when every degree is at most $k - 1$, then n is excluded.

In the chain with [2], the lower bounds of [2] on $e(3,k,n)$ for $11 \leq k \leq 13$ and $35 \leq n \leq 43$ are a further candidate for e_0 in (iii); at $k = 10$ they agree with those of [4]. Deleting a vertex as in [3, Lemma 3.5(a)] gives $m_k(n-1) + \max\{0, n - B_{k-1}\}$, as every degree is at least $n - B_{k-1}$. This never exceeds e_0 in either chain, so the certificates do not use it.

An extra step. We add one step, for $e = e_0, e_0 + 1, \ldots$ in turn. We enumerate every degree sequence with sum $2e$ and admissible entries, each at most $e - m_k(n-1)$, that satisfies the Graver–Yackel inequality. The cap on the entries holds as deleting v leaves a $(3, k; n-1)$-graph with $e - d_v$ edges.

We then try to exclude each sequence by a small linear programme. The *class* of an entry a is the set of the c_a vertices of degree a. The variables are the numbers $x_{ab} = x_{ba}$ of edges between the classes of $a \neq b$ and the numbers x_{aa} of edges inside a class. Counting edge ends, write $x_{a\to b} = x_{ab}$ for $a \neq b$ and $x_{a\to a} = 2x_{aa}$, so that $\sum_{d_v = a} Z_v = \sum_b b\, x_{a\to b}$. With $z_a = e - m_{k-1}(n - 1 - a)$, every $(3, k; n, e)$-graph with that degree sequence satisfies, for all entries a and b:

- $\sum_b x_{a\to b} = a\, c_a$;
- $\sum_b b\, x_{a\to b} \leq c_a z_a$, as G_v has $e - Z_v \geq m_{k-1}(n - 1 - a)$ edges;
- $\sum_b b\, x_{a\to b} \geq c_a\big(e - \lfloor (n-1-a)(k-2)/2 \rfloor\big)$, as G_v is a $(3, k-1)$-graph and so has maximum degree at most $k - 2$;
- $x_{ab} \leq c_a c_b$ for $a \neq b$;

- $\sum x_{ab} \le \lfloor N_S^2/4 \rfloor$, summed over $a \le b$ in S, for every set S of classes with N_S vertices in all (Mantel's theorem);
- $\sum_{b' \le b} x_{a \to b'} \ge t\, c_a$, with $t = t(a,b)$ as follows.

For the last constraint, let q be the least entry above b, and let v be a vertex of degree a. Remove from the sequence one term a, that of v. For $0 \le j \le a$, let $L(j)$ be the sum of the j smallest remaining terms at most b, counted with multiplicity, plus $(a-j)q$. Put $L(j) = \infty$ if fewer than j such terms remain, or if no entry of the sequence exceeds b (so that q is undefined) and $j < a$. If v has exactly j neighbours of degree at most b, then $L(j) \le Z_v \le z_a$ (so no such v exists when $L(j) = \infty$). So v has at least t such neighbours, where t is the least j with $L(j) \le z_a$, and summing over the class of a gives the last constraint. If there is no such j, no vertex of degree a exists and the sequence is excluded by this *neighbour-count test*.

If every sequence is excluded, so is e, and the step moves on to $e+1$. Each exclusion is certified either by the neighbour-count test or by rational Farkas multipliers, which combine these constraints, with $x \ge 0$, into an inequality $0 \ge c$ with $c > 0$.

Theorem 2.1 (computer-assisted)**.** *From the published values and lower bounds of [4, Theorem 2 and Tables 3–5] and* $\mathrm{R}(3,10) \le 42$ *[4, Theorem 6],* $\mathrm{R}(3,k)$ *is at most the value in the row "[4] only" of Table 2 for* $24 \le k \le 50$*. If the lower bounds on* $e(3,k,n)$ *in the table of [2, Section 5] are also used,* $\mathrm{R}(3,k)$ *is at most the value in the row "with [2]".*

k	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32
[4] only	201	216	231	247	264	280	297	315	333
with [2]	200	215	230	245	261	278	295	312	331
k	33	34	35	36	37	38	39	40	41
[4] only	351	370	389	409	429	450	471	492	513
with [2]	349	369	389	408	429	450	471	492	513
k	42	43	44	45	46	47	48	49	50
both	536	559	582	606	630	654	679	704	729

Table 2: Upper bounds for $\mathrm{R}(3,k)$ from Theorem 2.1. The two rows coincide for $k = 35$ and $k \ge 37$, and for $k \ge 42$ they are shown as one, "both". The survey [8] lists no upper bounds for these k. For comparison, $\mathrm{R}(3,k) \le \mathrm{R}(3,k-1) + k$, strict when both terms are even, iterated from the survey's $\mathrm{R}(3,23) \le 185$, gives 209, 234, 259, 371 and 1171 for $k = 24, 25, 26, 30, 50$. Shearer's bound [9] $\mathrm{R}(3,k) \le \lfloor (k-1)/f(k-1) \rfloor + 1$, with $f(d) = (d \ln d - d + 1)/(d-1)^2$, gives 223 for $k = 24$ and 792 for $k = 50$.

The two chains. Above level 10, each chain uses only the bounds B_{k-1} that it proves itself, never the unpublished values of [8]. Neither chain needs the bound $\mathrm{R}(3,10) \le 41$ of Angeltveit [1]. The report [2] is a preprint that gives little of its proofs, so the second row rests on inputs without published proofs. The first row is 1 to 3 larger for $24 \le k \le 34$ and $k = 36$, and equals the second for $k = 35$ and $k \ge 37$.

Without the extra step, the chain from [4] alone gives the same bounds for $11 \le k \le 50$, except $\mathrm{R}(3,20) \le 146$ and $\mathrm{R}(3,35) \le 390$. This run is not among the certificates in the ancillary

files. The certified chain from [4] alone, with the extra step, also reaches $e(3,13,51) \geq 178$ and $e(3,14,67) \geq 335$, which the comments column of [4, Tables 9 and 10] credits to Backelin. It raises seven further lower bounds of [4, Tables 9–11] by one, to

$$e(3,13,58) \geq 261, \qquad e(3,14,69) \geq 366, \qquad e(3,14,70) \geq 382,$$
$$e(3,15,n) \geq 516,\ 534,\ 553 \text{ and } 573 \quad \text{for } n = 82,\ldots,85.$$

These are values $m_k(n)$ recorded in the certificate of that chain, so the checker of Theorem 2.1 verifies them. They lie beyond the range $n \leq 43$ of [2]. Backelin's unpublished manuscript, to which [8] credits $\mathrm{R}(3,17) \leq 109$, may already contain them.

Checking the certificates. The certificates are checked by a program that does not import the generating code. It enumerates the degree sequences itself, rebuilds each constraint from its definition, and verifies the multipliers in exact arithmetic.

- The chain with [2] has one row for each level $11 \leq k \leq 50$ and each order $0 \leq n < B_k$, 13,376 rows in all. Each row records $m_k(n)$ and the bound of (iii) that gives e_0: the Radziszowski–Kreher bound, a value of [2], or the two ends of the hull edge. At the orders where the extra step is used, it also records a certificate for every degree sequence at each excluded e. A further row per level, not counted here, certifies the exclusion of B_k: by (ii) at every level except $k = 16$, where the extra step excludes every e at $n = 97$. The chain excludes 765 degree sequences at 53 triples (k,n,e) (including those at $k = 16$, $n = 97$), 686 by the neighbour-count test and 79 by Farkas multipliers.
- The chain from [4] alone has 13,403 rows and excludes 766 sequences at 50 triples, 684 and 82 respectively. All 40 exclusions of B_k in it are by (ii).

Comparison with the survey. For $11 \leq k \leq 23$ the two chains give the following bounds B_k, against the upper bounds that [8] lists.

k	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23
survey [8]	50	59	68	77	87	97	109	120	132	145	157	171	185
[4] only	50	59	68	77	87	98	109	121	133	145	159	173	187
with [2]	50	59	68	77	87	97	109	121	132	145	158	172	185

So for $11 \leq k \leq 23$ the procedure improves no value of [8]. From [4] alone it gives $\mathrm{R}(3,17) \leq 109$ and $\mathrm{R}(3,20) \leq 145$, which [8] credits to that manuscript of Backelin and to Lesser's thesis [6], respectively. With the table of [2] it gives $\mathrm{R}(3,16) \leq 97$ and $\mathrm{R}(3,19) \leq 132$, the values that [8] lists, citing [2].

With the table of [2] it also gives $\mathrm{R}(3,23) \leq 185$. The survey [8] credits this bound to a personal communication of Backelin; it now has a derivation that can be checked, given the inputs of [2]. At $k = 18$, 21 and 22 the values of [8] come from unpublished sources, and the chain with [2] misses each by one.

For $k = 18$, both chains give $m_{18}(120) = 1020 = 120 \cdot 17/2$ from the hull. As every degree is at most 17, a $(3,18;120)$-graph would have exactly 1020 edges and be 17-regular. Then every G_v would be a $(3,17;102,731)$-graph, as $120 - 1 - 17 = 102$ and $1020 - 17^2 = 731$. So $e(3,17,102) \geq 732$, one more than our $m_{17}(102) = 731$, would exclude $n = 120$ and give $\mathrm{R}(3,18) \leq 120$. This 120 is the upper bound that [8] lists for $\mathrm{R}(3,18)$, from an unpublished

source, so $e(3,17,102) \geq 732$ would give a checkable proof of that known bound, not a new bound.

3 Lower bounds for $\mathrm{R}(4,k)$

For a prime $p \equiv 1 \pmod 8$ let Q_p be the circulant graph on $\mathbb{Z}_p$ in which $x \sim y$ if and only if $x - y$ is a nonzero fourth power. The relation is symmetric, as -1 is a fourth power. Lindsay and Cain [7, Proposition 2.1] computed with cliquer that Q_{313} and Q_{457} have clique number 3 and independence numbers

$$\alpha(Q_{313}) = 21 \qquad \text{and} \qquad \alpha(Q_{457}) = 24.$$

The ancillary checks confirm $\alpha(Q_{313}) = 21$ and show that Q_{457} has an independent 24-set.

Theorem 3.1 does not use the upper bounds on $\alpha(Q_p)$. An independent set of size at least k contains one of size k. So if a vertex set S meets every independent k-set of Q_p, then $Q_p - S$ is K_4-free and has no independent k-set. Step 3 below checks this for $(p,k) = (313,21)$ and $(457,24)$, and the K_4-freeness of both graphs $Q_p - S$ is also checked directly.

Theorem 3.1 (witnesses checked by computer)**.** $\mathrm{R}(4,21) \geq 260$ *and* $\mathrm{R}(4,24) \geq 370$.

Proof. Step 1: symmetries and cosets. The maps $x \mapsto ax + b$ with a a nonzero fourth power are automorphisms of Q_p. Let O_1, O_2, O_3 be the cosets of the group of nonzero fourth powers in $\mathbb{Z}_p^*$ other than the group itself, in a fixed order, and let r_j be the least element of O_j.

Step 2: representatives. Let $k \geq 2$, let J be an independent k-set and let $u \in J$. The translate $J - u = \{x - u : x \in J\}$ is an independent k-set that contains 0, so its other elements are not fourth powers and lie in $O_1 \cup O_2 \cup O_3$. Let j be least with $J - u$ meeting O_j, say at w. Then r_j/w is a fourth power, and multiplying by it maps $J - u$ to an independent k-set that contains 0 and r_j and still avoids $O_1, \ldots, O_{j-1}$, as multiplication by a fourth power fixes each coset. Call an independent k-set a *representative* if, for some j, it contains 0 and r_j and avoids $O_1, \ldots, O_{j-1}$. So every independent k-set is the image of a representative under one of the maps above.

Step 3: the computation. The sets S, of 54 and 88 vertices, were found by a weighted local search and are listed in the ancillary files. An exact program lists all representatives for $(p,k) = (313,21)$ and $(457,24)$, by an exhaustive search for independent $(k-2)$-sets in the common non-neighbourhood of 0 and r_j outside $O_1, \ldots, O_{j-1}$. It then checks that S meets every image of every representative. So $Q_{313} - S$ is a K_4-free graph on 259 vertices with no independent 21-set, and $Q_{457} - S$ one on 369 vertices with no independent 24-set. □

Verification. Both graphs are rebuilt from the lists of deleted vertices by programs that share no code with the search. The 259-vertex graph is also checked by a direct exhaustive search for K_4 and for independent 21-sets, and the 369-vertex graph by one for K_4 and for independent 24-sets. Neither search uses symmetry, so each is independent of the orbit argument above. □

Comparison with earlier bounds. The previous bounds are as follows.

- For $R(4,21)$, the survey has 242 [10], and $R(4,20) \geq 252$ from a recent preprint [11] gives 257 by the inequality $R(4,l) \geq R(4,l-1)+5$ [8, 2.3(e)].
- For $R(4,24)$, the non-neighbourhood of a vertex of Q_{457} (Q_{457} is 114-regular) has 342 vertices, is K_4-free and has no independent 24-set, as such a set would extend by the vertex. This gives $R(4,24) \geq 343$. The survey lists no value for $R(4,24)$. The inequality [8, 2.3(e)], applied twice to $R(4,22) \geq 314$ [7], gives 324.

The method does not reach $R(4,23) \geq 320$, which would improve the bound 319 that this inequality gives from $R(4,22) \geq 314$. That needs a set of at most $457 - 319 = 138$ vertices meeting every independent 23-set of Q_{457}, and the smallest we found has 147.

4 Verification, literature and limitations

Ancillary files. This paper and [3] have the same ancillary files, which are also in the directory `ancillary/` of the repository

`https://github.com/Lachy-Dauth/ramsey-neighbourhood-counting`.

They contain the programs and data, among them:

- `two_colour_r3k/` for Theorem 2.1, with the inputs from [4] and [2] and the certificates of both chains;
- `two_colour_r4k/` for Theorem 3.1, with the lists of deleted vertices, `build_power_sub.py`, which rebuilds the two graphs from them, the exact checkers `rcheck.c` (direct search) and `qpsym.c` (orbit argument), and `verify_all.sh`, which checks the SHA-256 hashes of the two graphs and runs the checkers.

The command `sh run_all.sh` runs the quick checks of both papers in a few minutes. The command `sh run_all.sh --full` adds the long ones, among them the direct search of the 369-vertex graph for independent 24-sets.

The checkers for this paper, in `two_colour_r3k/` and `two_colour_r4k/`, are written in Python and C with their standard libraries, and the C programs use POSIX threads. To run only these checks, use the commands in `two_colour_r3k/README.md` and the script `two_colour_r4k/verify_all.sh`. The script `run_all.sh` also needs a C++17 compiler, for the checks of [3], and uses NumPy, when it is installed, for an optional second checker of that paper and its negative controls [3, Section 10]. Negative controls are all rejected: a weakened input, a zeroed multiplier, a removed sequence certificate, a value raised by one, a claimed bound below the proved one such as $R(3,24) \leq 199$, and a deleted vertex put back.

Literature. We searched arXiv and the web up to 23 October 2026 for earlier statements of our new bounds, and found none.

- For $R(3,k)$ with $k \geq 24$ the survey lists no upper bounds, and the upper bounds of [4] and of Lesser's thesis [6] stop at $k = 16$ and $k = 21$. Backelin's unpublished manuscript (Section 2) may contain bounds of this kind.

- For $\mathrm{R}(4,21)$ the best previous bound we know of, 257, follows from $\mathrm{R}(4,20) \geq 252$ in the preprint [11], which we have not checked. Without it the bound is 242 [10].
- For $\mathrm{R}(4,24)$ the survey lists nothing, and 343 is implicit in [7].

Such a search cannot establish priority, and we would welcome pointers to any earlier source.

Limitations. For $11 \leq k \leq 23$ the bootstrap of Section 2 improves none of the bounds in [8]. At $k = 18$ it would give $\mathrm{R}(3,18) \leq 120$ if its own lower bound $e(3,17,102) \geq 731$ were one larger. This would be a checkable proof of the bound that [8] lists from an unpublished source, not a new bound. The second row of Table 2 rests on the lower bounds of [2], whose proofs are largely unpublished.

The deletion method of Section 3 does not reach $\mathrm{R}(4,23) \geq 320$.

Acknowledgements

Much of the work reported here was carried out with two AI systems, used under the direction of the author: OpenAI's Codex, based on GPT-6, and Claude Opus 5.5, a large language model developed by Anthropic. They searched for the arguments and certificates, wrote the search programs for this paper (not included) and the checking programs in the ancillary files, and drafted the text. Every certificate and witness is checked in exact arithmetic by the programs in the ancillary files (see Section 4), which can be run without either AI system. The author takes full responsibility for the contents of this paper.

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